



Course Evaluations Spring 2026, period 1

Course Director Report for 5329 Inequality, Household Behavior, & the Macroeconomy



Report prepared by **Atli Hallgrímsson**
Created **Tuesday, March 31, 2026**



Courses Audience: 28
Responses Received: 18
Response Ratio: 64.29 %

Report Comments

The content of this report is intended for the course director. Please be cautious when discussing the results and do not distribute the report outside the School. The Stockholm School of Economics is committed to ensuring the protection of personal data and the integrity of students and employees.

All ratings are on a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 is “disagree strongly” and 7 is “agree strongly”.

The total teacher average is calculated regardless of the number of responses to each question. This means that the three teacher-related questions have the same weight.

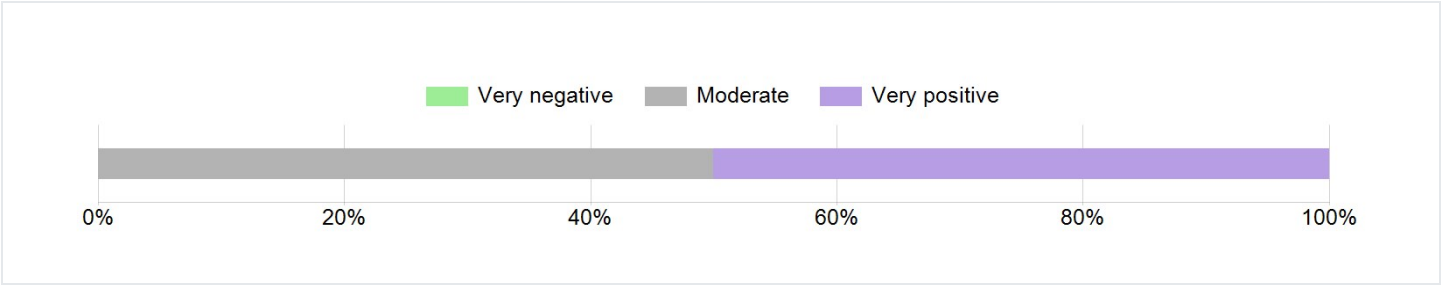
N.B. If there are course feedback surveys closing after the end of the current study period, this report might be updated.

For CIVICA courses, only students registered in SSE's student information system were surveyed.

If this report is for a mandatory course in one of SSE's programs, this report will also be shared with the program director directly.

Please contact SSEquality@hhs.se if you have any questions.

Course Satisfaction (scale distribution)



Course Satisfaction

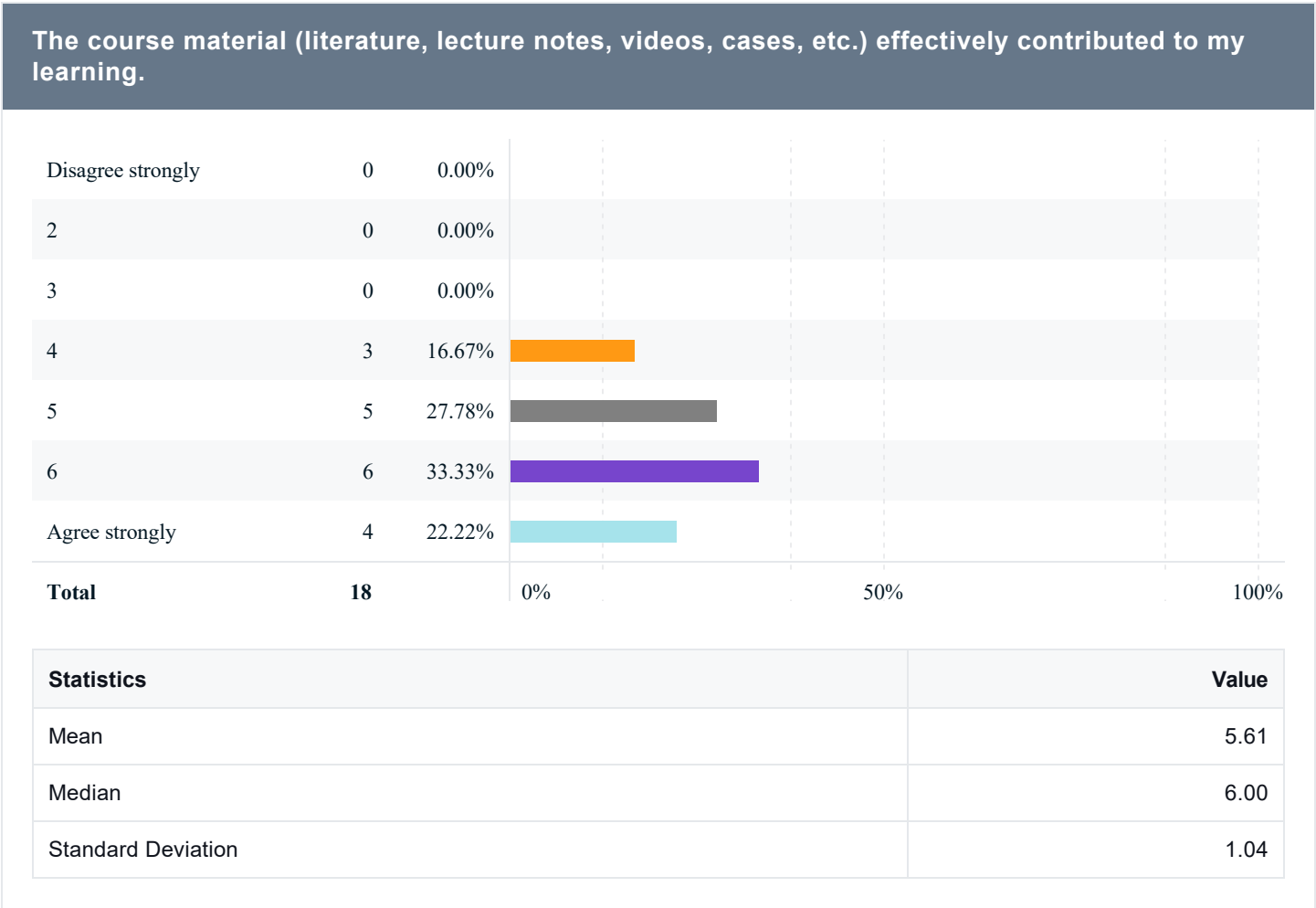
Overall, I am satisfied with the quality of this course.

Disagree strongly	0	0.00%	
2	0	0.00%	
3	0	0.00%	
4	2	11.11%	
5	7	38.89%	
6	4	22.22%	
Agree strongly	5	27.78%	
Total	18		

Statistics	Value
Mean	5.67
Median	5.50
Standard Deviation	1.03

SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.29	1.52	1282

Course Material



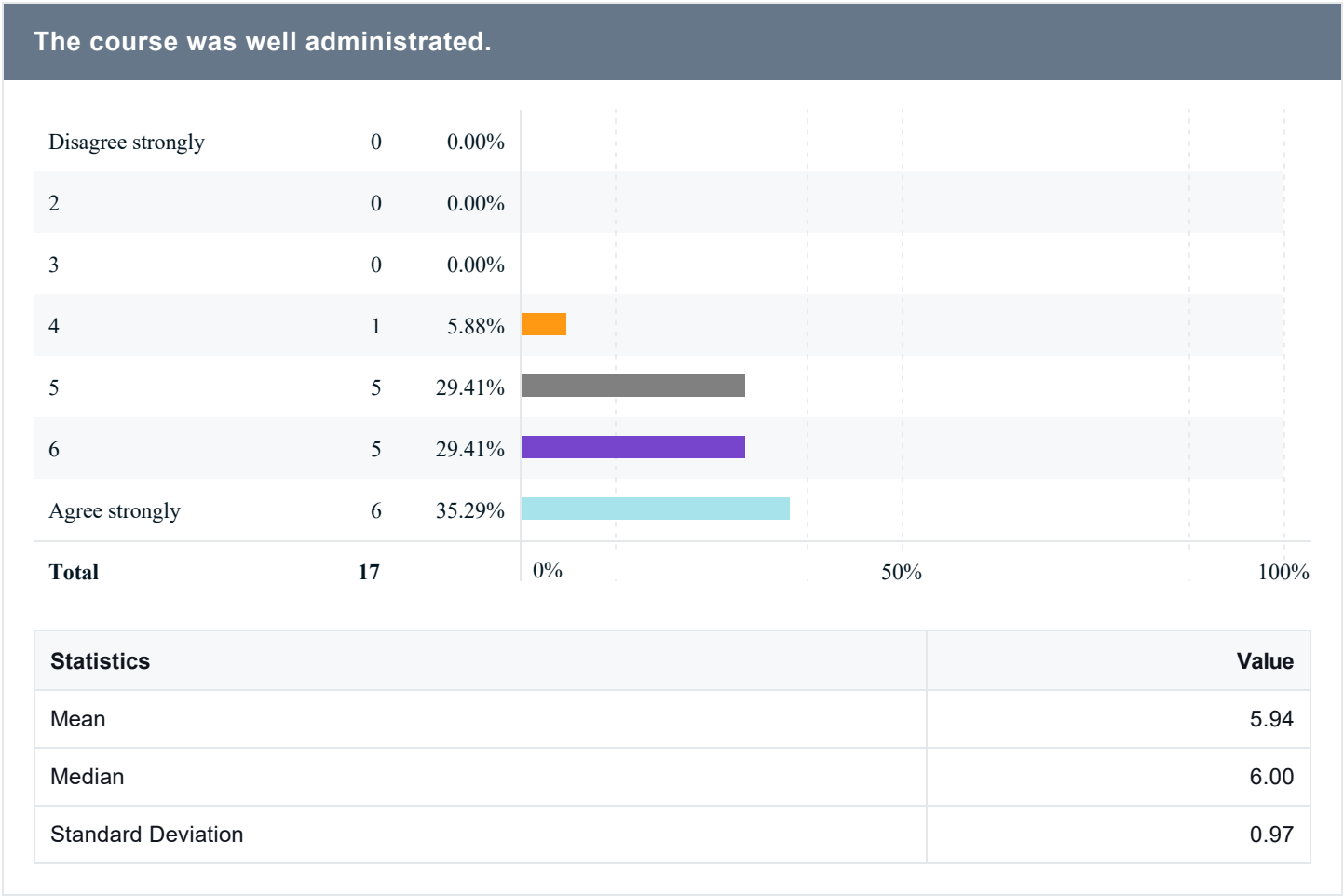
SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.23	1.51	1209

Time Spent on Course



SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.43	1.36	1203

Administration



SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.72	1.34	1196

Do you have any specific feedback on the course administration?

Comment

The second assignment was really long and it felt like we didn't have enough time to do question 2. It also would've been nice to know the assignment due dates at the start of/early on in the course.

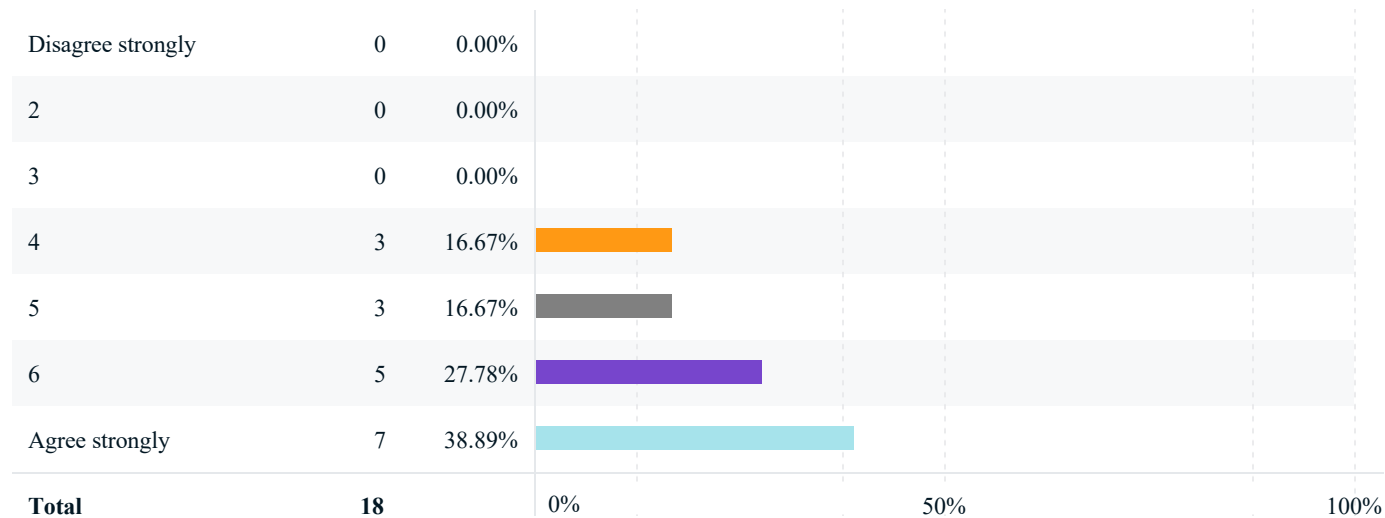
Great administration. Schedule was always clear, Zoltan has excellent timing within lectures, so hardly falls behind or finishes early. PSet feedback could have been a bit faster.

It was good.

Clearly, a lot of effort was put into preparing this course, which is very helpful for us. As mentioned, the balance between home assignments and in-class teaching and learning is well designed. Maybe the balance between time spent on the coding part and time spent discussing theory could be reassessed: carefully unpacking the mechanism behind how the code works was clearly useful, but as we moved to more complex solving methods (using Lagrangian and savings grid – although, I actually thought that was more intuitive than Bellman and cash on hand, which I only understood as a concept very late, despite being fundamental to the course) we gave up fully understanding the code anyways. It was a bit strange to realise that we were half way through the course but had only progressed to Zeldes or so.

Sustainability

This course has enhanced my understanding of how course content relates to sustainable development (e.g. environmental, social and economic aspects).



Statistics	Value
Mean	5.89
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.13

SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.05	1.72	1184

What were the strengths of this course? Please be specific and use concrete examples where possible.

Comment
First course where you really got to learn code. Good extension to the macro course regarding incorporating inequality and uncertainty.
The assignments were good length and fun to do.
Interesting topics, connected to relevant papers, well annotated papers (what to read and not read), good intro to programming in julia.
The course had a clear structure where it felt that each lecture/assignment built on previous lectures/assignments.
I really liked how well the papers that we read related to the overall course structure, it made it feel like there was a story told throughout and made it much easier to understand as the models were pretty complex at times. Zoltan is a great instructor. I also felt like the coding component integrated really well with the course material and I appreciated how we actually learned how to code to understand how the models worked.
clear good slides
The topic is interesting. I also liked the mix between research paper, theory, math/models, intuition, programming.
Zoltan is a good professor and very open to questions. Content of the course is good.
The course introduces essential concepts and tools in advanced Econ in a very digestible manner. Teaching a new language with Julia during the course is ambitious but works out perfectly fine. Zoltan really brings across his motivation and fascination for the topics. Nice selection of papers, I enjoyed reading most of them. The biggest strength imo is that Zoltan weaves new concepts like the endogeneous grid point method or Bellman nicely into the paper and an intuitive interpretation of the papers so that there appears to be an access angle for students on every level.
Especially the papers during the later half of the course were super interesting as they were mostly more recent
Zoltan is a very dependable and engaged teacher. The course is correctly calibrated in terms of difficulty.
I liked that we had the opportunity to put theory into practice with the Julia assignments, this helped me understanding the course better.
I was really excited about this course since the day Zoltan pitched it to us last term. It's very refreshing to get to study inequality, a highly relevant subject (especially given the common critique that economics teaching is lacking this aspect). It's always great to be taught by professors who are excited about the subject, and Zoltan was clearly very engaged. This course is a very ambitious one: it seeks to achieve multiple hard things, from introducing us to economic modelling in a language we've never used before, to advancing our theoretical knowledge of consumption and savings models, to (even) uncovering topics in mathematics (which probably the math course should have covered had it not been so focused on abstract topology or whatever we did in the first term). The materials we used – the pre-written code files – were essential and showed diligence on the part of Zoltan. Plus, the structure of the course is smart: complex homework assignments seriously graded, paired with a more theoretical exam.
Great content, and very relevant course. I really feel like I learned a lot, and especially related to the behavioral motives that households take when making decisions. Also very nice to learn models and a different coding language.

How could this course be improved? Please be specific and use concrete examples where possible.

Comment

I was new to Julia and the coding got very difficult very fast. I did not manage to have time to understand it and follow the lectures where we discussed code.

Sometimes it was difficult to understand what we were doing and what it meant. More background introduction to topic each lecture might be good, and after every result explain what they mean more clearly.

The seminars lacked structure and unfortunately I learned nothing there. Some stuff taught felt like it contradicted what was taught in class. Put more focus on a good seminar that is only there for written solutions that will help us in the exam.

I think many choose this course because of interest in inequality, not just using it in models. Maybe market the course a bit differently.

A lot of the problem sets included solving models on paper, something that was not done in detail in class. Given that the models are relatively complex, it would be nice to see it done more.

Also, another class on Julia that breaks down model solving in smaller chunks would have been useful (like the intro classes but focused on model solving).

Please do not use Julia.

I think it could've been useful to add a slide or some written material about the codes that we reviewed in class, since it would've been nice to be able to reference some of this for the assignments and in case we missed on the lectures where we discussed the code.

more questions to use for exam practice

I think clarity is has a big potential. More clarity when choosing the course (many thought it would be more prescriptive and less math-y). More clarity in how all topics connect together. Once I started studying for the exam it all started to make sense and I started liking the topic and course a lot more — maybe there's a way to 'force' students to study earlier in the period so they make themselves a better overview of everything earlier?

You must market the course differently. When you say "Inequality", people think about the subject from a political point of view. Questions such as "shall we have equality of opportunity and equality of outcome". They do not think about math and models. It must become clearer that this is a quantitative course and not a qualitative course.

I was sceptical about this course for the first month but later on it became more interesting. I think a lot of that has to do with how you structure the course. I do not think it is good to be too technical and have too much math and models. The findings and implications of the papers are what is really interesting. This course would be 10x better if it was structured like the Development Economics course (which is also based on papers). Please talk to Celine to see her way of structuring both the lectures and the exam.

The coding does not do anything for the students. Most people do not learn Julia, they learn how to ask Claude to do the code for them. I do not understand why you have such difficult assignments that take such long time, when the benefit for the student is next to zero. It would be better if you for instance gave each group a different paper (not a starred one) and that we make a presentation about that paper. Or maybe that we make a policy report regarding some inequality topic. This would benefit us much more and we would learn much more. Especially since the assignments are not even useful for exam prep.

Your ppt decks are okay, but when studying a lot of students needed chat gpt to explain a lot of slides, since they do not stand by themselves. I suggest you take a look at Jaakko or Elenas ppt decks (in econometrics and micro) to see how a self-standing ppt deck shall look like. Otherwise, studying becomes very troublesome.

Comment

These points are only minor: I think the structure could be made a bit clearer at the beginning, i.e., that we will deal with “unconstrained” optimization first, then slowly introduce five big constraints: borrowing constraints, uncertainty, bequests, entrepreneurship and returns.

The coding part could be integrated into the slides more (e.g. including and interpreting the output graphs in the slides)

I would not know.

It could be useful to spend a bit more time on the more challenging concepts, or to use the final lecture to tie everything together into one coherent story.

The course would benefit from a clearer structure communicated from the start. It took several weeks to realise how the content was organised, probably because the topics at the beginning of the course are not clearly differentiated. Even though each lecture had its own structure, the overall progression could be laid out more explicitly.

Another major area is real-world applicability. For example, when it came to capital income taxes or consumption taxes, I was curious about how they manifest in practice. I was also interested in how these papers measure consumption, and in seeing concrete numbers behind how people actually save. It still feels somewhat abstract to me, for instance in contexts where investment mainly takes the form of property ownership, but I did not gain enough intuition to connect the theory to real systems.

I understand this is not a political philosophy course, but I hoped to gain enough grounding to draw my own normative conclusions. After the course, while I can solve models and understand the theory, the level of abstraction at times left me feeling unequipped to confidently apply these concepts to real-life economic questions.

There is also likely some mismatch regarding the expected mathematical background. This is not Zoltan's fault, but it suggests that Mark's and Elena's courses could be better aligned with the needs of the programme. While Zoltan was always helpful in explaining things, this is still something worth taking into account. I personally would have benefited from more concrete examples of worked optimisation problems. Because the course is so broad in scope, there is limited time to practise solving multiple problems and to build confidence in applying the methods.

The lectures were sometimes difficult to follow, especially the math, although I understand since math is difficult to teach in class. Might have been beneficial to go through the steps on the whiteboard instead of slides, as that is what we do in the math and time series courses and usually students find that helpful to see someone actually go through the steps.

Teacher Questions

Q1: The teacher effectively advanced and facilitated my learning.
Q2: I received the help I needed from the teacher in an appropriate time frame.
Total: Overall of All Questions

If no tables are displayed in this section, no teacher-specific questions were included in the survey.

Teacher Zoltan Racz

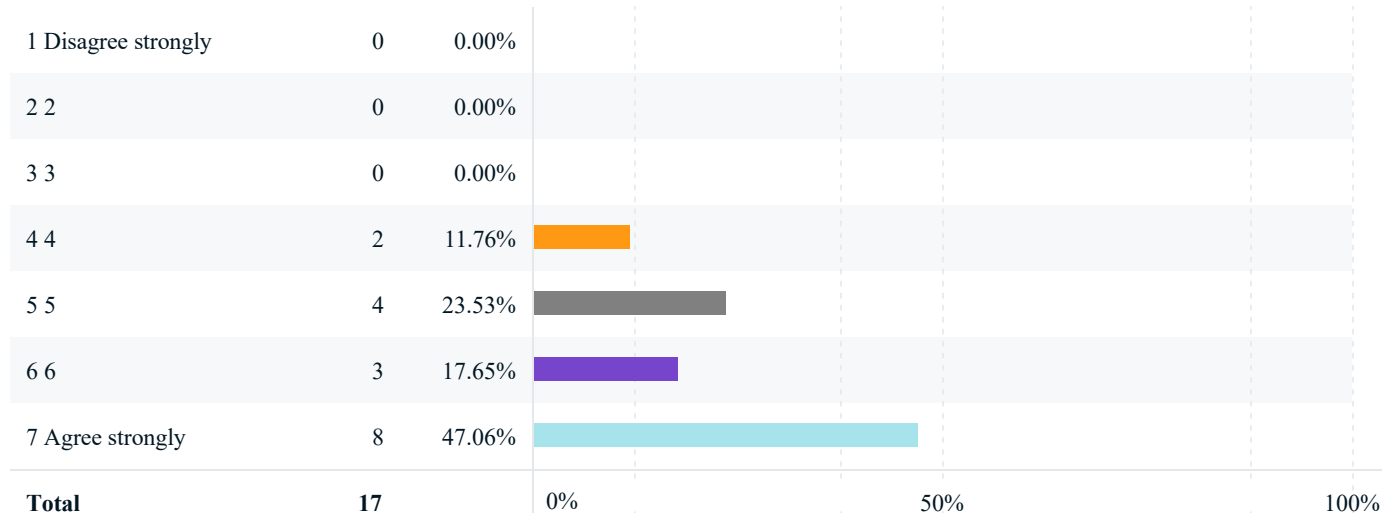
	Q1			Q2		
	Mean	SD	Resp	Mean	SD	Resp
Overall	6.33	0.77	18	6.57	0.65	14

SSE Average, current period

	Q1			Q2		
	Mean	SD	Resp	Mean	SD	Resp
Overall	5.63	1.49	2156	5.96	1.38	1825

Equality and Diversity

In this course, the teacher(s) actively worked to include different people and perspectives. This was demonstrated in, for example, the selection of course materials, case studies and/or guest speakers as well as during lectures and classroom discussions through balanced speaking time and avoiding stereotypical examples.



Statistics	Value
Mean	6.00
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.12

SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 26	5.78	1.38	1130

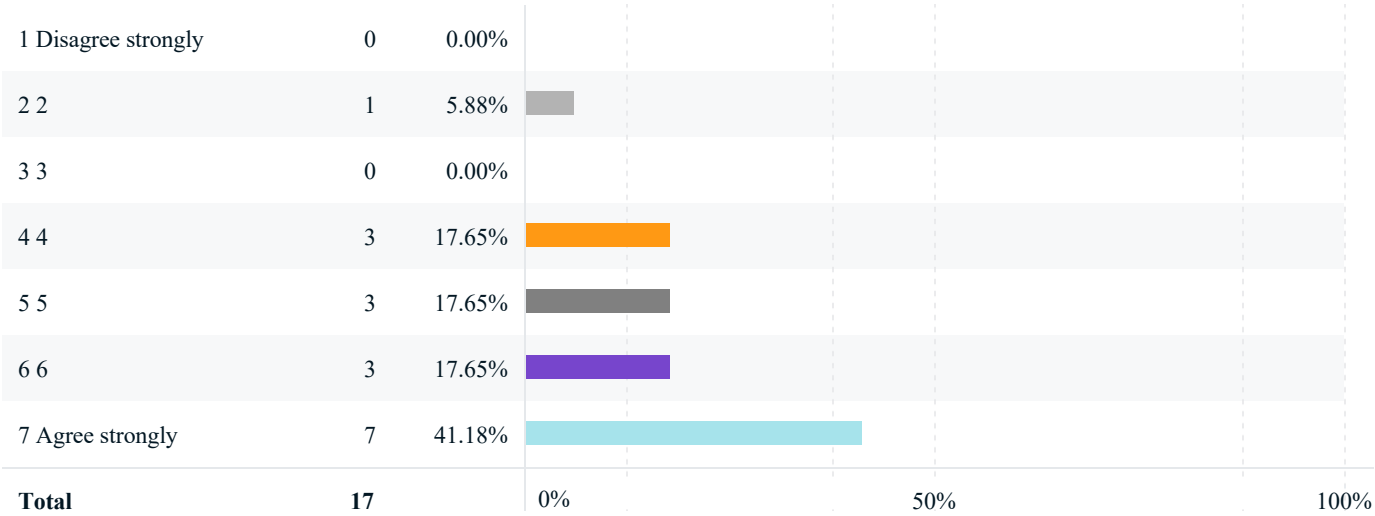
What concrete, constructive suggestions do you have for integrating a diversity, equity and inclusion perspective in this course?

Note: Course evaluations are confidential. If you would like to report a specific incident, please send an email to Olivia.Marrero.Engstrom@hhs.se. Your e-mail will be handled in strict confidence. You can also use the anonymous whistleblowing tool <https://hhs.whistlelink.com/>.

Comment
The course itself focused on inequality, so not much more to add — perhaps could include how income inequality is related to other types of inequality.
We talk a lot about how poor vs rich make decisions etc. but we could spend some time talking about who is more likely to be poor (e.g. women, immigrants, low education etc.), why, and how for example taxation could mitigate that.
/
/

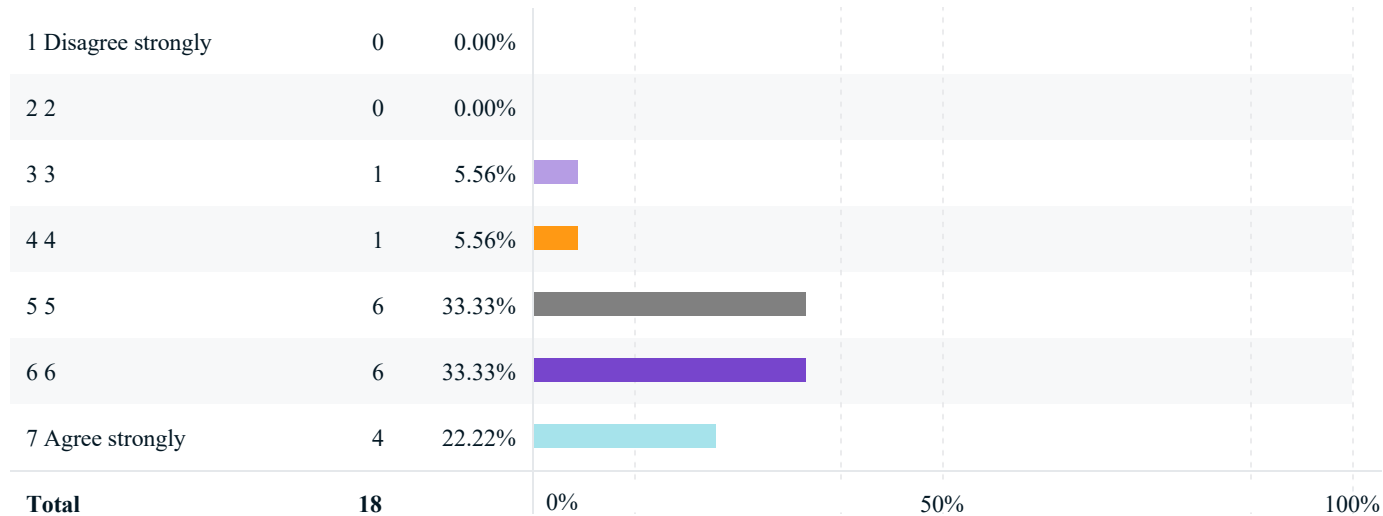
Course Questions

1. It was valuable to learn from research articles.



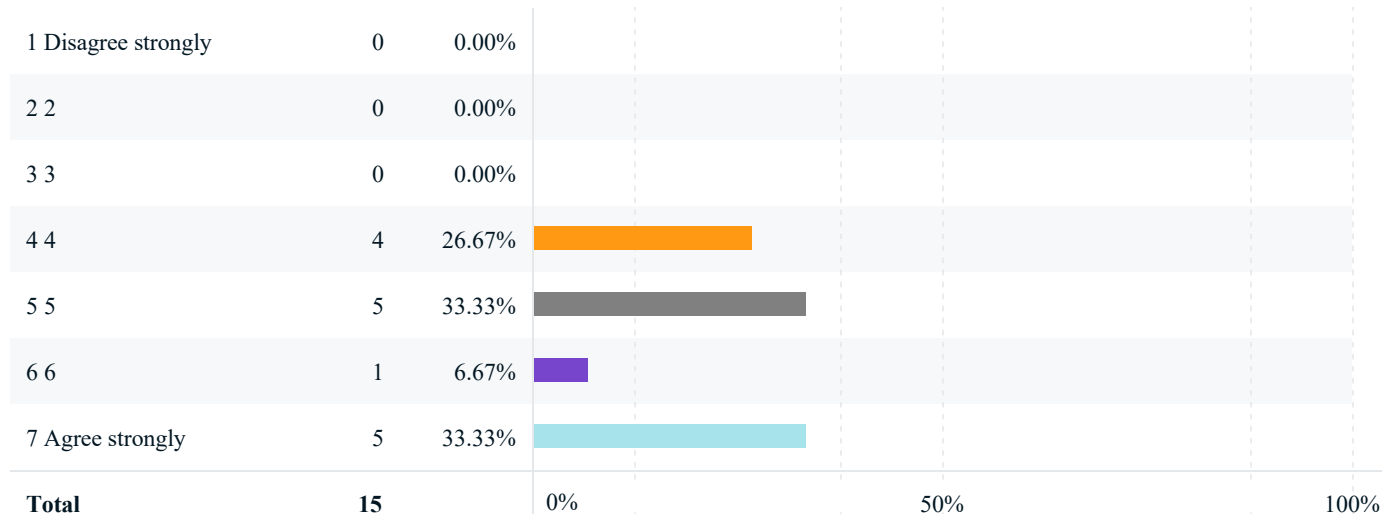
Statistics	Value
Mean	5.65
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.50

2. The course workload and requirements were appropriate for the course level.



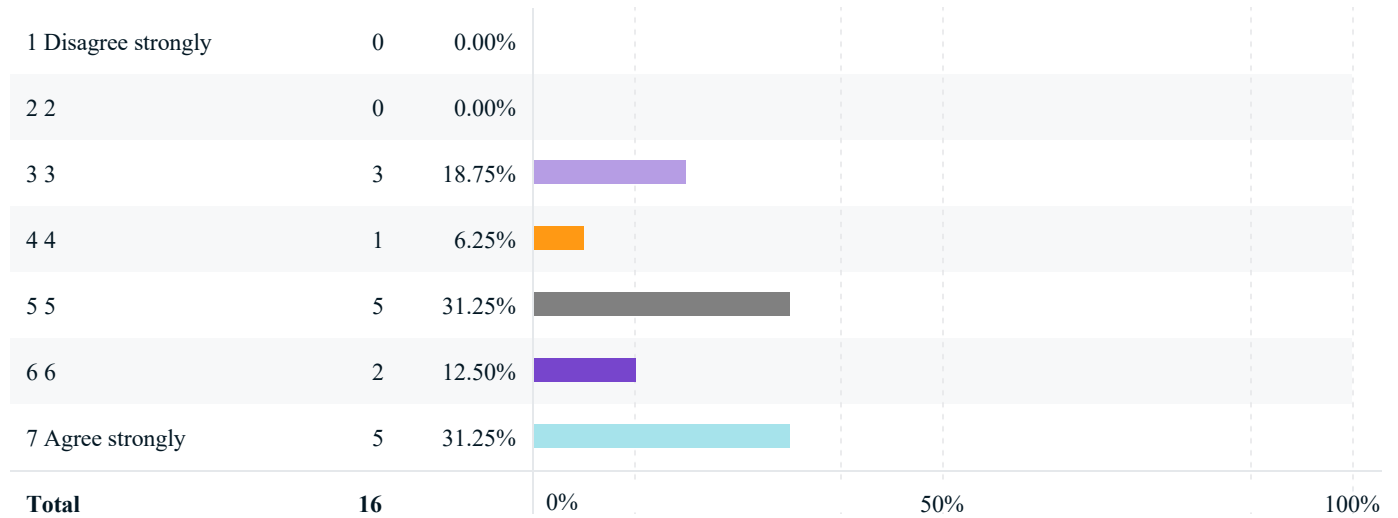
Statistics	Value
Mean	5.61
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.09

3. The support my teaching assistant(s) provided contributed to my learning in the course.



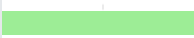
Statistics	Value
Mean	5.47
Median	5.00
Standard Deviation	1.25

4. The teaching assistant(s) was well prepared.



Statistics	Value
Mean	5.31
Median	5.00
Standard Deviation	1.49

The tempo of this course was challenging to follow.

1 Yes	4	23.53%		
2 No	13	76.47%		
Total	17		0%	50% 100%

Statistics	Value
Mean	1.76
Median	2.00
Standard Deviation	0.44

Comment

- If you have not taken advanced math and macroeconomics at the masters level at SSE you might have found it really difficult. But for me, it was challenging but not in a bad way.

- It was not challenging to understand the majority of concepts via economic intuition. But it was challenging to solve the models, more whiteboard solving in class would have been helpful.

- I personally felt that solving optimality conditions was challenging early on since it was a long time since I have had to solve this type of problems and never with this level of complexity.

- No, but I relied heavily on my math and macro background to understand the course content, without this preparation I think I would've struggled.

- it was challenging because I missed some lectures due to work but if you attend everything I think it's a reasonable level, challenging but not stressfully so

- The math caught me a bit off-guard because to be honest I'd forgotten all from Mark's course. But the level in this course was 'low' enough that I could easily get back to it.

- Bear in mind that most students who took Marks math course, still have forgotten a lot of it when the Spring starts.

- - - -

- I found that the first few lectures were quite intimidating (and sometimes unnecessarily complex) which was a bit discouraging, but the later half was super interesting and made me want to keep up more

- Maths background (as taught at SSE) should be improved to do well in this course – I had no idea about uncertainty and its effects on optimisation before.

- At first, yes, but it was fine once the math part was done and got easier to follow in the latter part. Instead of Julia, might have been better to have a lecture on the math part was challenging and more interesting to me.

Which topics would you have liked to spend more time on?

Comment
More background and concrete examples on inequality today. But as I understood later in the course this was not the idea of the course.
Wealth inequality
I think the time spent on each topic was sufficient.
The course got much more interesting after the Carroll and Samwick paper and onwards, so I would've loved more time to understand these parts and especially the policy implications discussed at the end of the course. I also really liked the last lecture discussion of how to set up our own model to solve the debt repayment problem in the US, it felt like there were a lot of things that clicked for me about model choices during that discussion that maybe would've been beneficial to understand a bit earlier in the course. I also really like the addition of the Nekoei and Seim paper, and generally liked the papers that used interesting data and felt like they were more applicable to the real world, so I would've enjoyed more of this.
maybe something about subsidies? as another redistribution mechanism other than taxes. or something about what the government does with the taxes.
Taxes and their many implications
This is a personal taste, but I really enjoyed (optimal) taxation. However, to get there one has to deal with the other topics before, so I would not demand to give it more room unless there was more overall time resources available. What I definitely would have liked to spend less time on is Nikoei and Seim. Horrible writing style, they make matters unnecessarily complicated by arrogant notation. Maybe there would be a better paper on a similar issue?
Taxation (wealth and inheritance taxes), maybe talking about different real life examples
/
/
I still feel that I do not fully understand how the policy mechanisms we discussed, such as different types of taxes, manifest in real life. For example, I am not sure what it concretely means for a capital income tax to be levied, or how people actually hold and accumulate savings in practice. Similarly, I am unsure how certain forms of consumption are treated. If, for instance, a car is purchased by one person but used by another, how does that relate to the way consumption is defined and taxed, and what does that imply for the conclusions of our models? Strengthening the link between theoretical models and actual household behaviour would have been very valuable.
Related to this, the course could place more emphasis on normative implications. We briefly touched on this, for example, in discussions about the difficulty of implementing wealth taxation, but there is room to develop this aspect further. More discussion along these lines would help connect the analytical tools to broader economic reasoning.
Different kinds of utility functions, especially what happens when inequality enters the utility function itself. Why is this something that is difficult to implement? Has someone tried (and failed)?